

The use of film in re-imaging a tourism destination: a case study of Yorkshire, UK

Journal of Vacation Marketing
16(1) 61–74
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DOI: 10.1177/1356766709356611
jvm.sagepub.com



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Abstract

The primary focus of this article is to provide a theoretical insight into the relationship between film induced tourism and destination imagery, which in turn can be used to market a tourism destination. In order to achieve this, strategic conversations were carried out with the key stakeholders behind the development of the Yorkshire (UK) brand. Yorkshire will be used as the lens through which the film induced tourism phenomenon will be observed as it is the film location for many popular English television series. In addition, this article draws upon the literature background and the theoretical context of the film induced tourism phenomenon in relation to destination imagery. The issues which emerged from these and the literature review highlighted many implications for the future development of these locations such as the use of destination imagery in the promotion of a film location.

Keywords

Film, image, media, tourism, Yorkshire

Introduction

O'Connor et al., (2008) maintain that in the midst of some exceptions (Beeton, 2005; Busby and Klug, 2001; Connell, 2005a, 2005b; Riley et al., 1998; Tooke and Baker, 1996), most of the tourism related literature on film induced tourism,¹ consists of unconfirmed statements on the monetary importance of this phenomenon. Numerous films are based on books (Haworth and the Brontë sisters), as are a high proportion on television series. A great deal of the subjective studies are cited in Tooke and Baker's (1996) work, which reflects on four case studies from British television: *To the Manor Born* (1979–2007), *By the Sword Divided* (1983–1985), *Middlemarch* (1994) and *Heartbeat* (1992–present). They also talk about *Cadfael* (1994–1998), a historical detective television series, filmed in Hungary, which still entices

big numbers of tourists to Shrewsbury, where the novels were set (Riley et al., 1998).

The primary focus of this article is to provide a theoretical insight into the relationship between film induced tourism and destination imagery, which in turn can be used to market a tourism destination. The objectives of this research guided and directed the research effort throughout so as to identify the film induced images that tourists presently have of Yorkshire and also to:

- Evaluate the level of imagery that Yorkshire has in the mind of the tourist;
- Identify if tourists are aware of Yorkshire based television series;

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- Discover the images, if any, that tourists associate with the three Yorkshire based television series under review.

To satisfy these objectives, an interdisciplinary approach was adapted. Insights from a variety of areas such as tourism and marketing were utilized and incorporated into the research framework. This gathering of data from a variety of disciplines was necessary given the nature of the topic being researched. Following an extensive review of the literature, it was noted that there was a significant research gap in relation to how film induced tourism could be used to market a destination. Most of the existing tourism decision models did not reflect the present-day academic research and as such an updated model was required. In response to these primary gaps, a two phased approach was adopted; the first involved gathering and analyzing quantitative data (tourist survey) regarding the film induced tourist, while the second phase consisted of strategic conversations with the key tourism and film stakeholders behind the Yorkshire brand.

In addition, this article draws upon the literature and the background and the theoretical context of the film induced tourism phenomenon in relation to destination imagery. It cannot be assumed that the results from this research could be used to benchmark other such destinations on how to market themselves based on film induced tourism, as each destination has difficult variables to manage such as political and government enforced strategies and plans. Although there are reasons to be cautious about generalizing in relation to these findings, there is little doubt that many of the themes and issues could be applicable to other such tourism destinations. The main findings of this study add to the current data relating to film induced tourism. The phenomenon has been largely overlooked by academic researchers with few detailed examinations of this topic ever carried out. Consequently, this research goes some way to filling this knowledge gap (Tooke and Baker, 1996).

Film induced tourism in the UK

The UK has been the filming location for over 100 international films and television dramas, comprising some very successful productions like *Four Weddings and a Funeral* (1994), *Braveheart* (1995), *Rob Roy* (1995), *Loch Ness* (1995), *The Full Monty* (1997), *Notting Hill*

(1999) and *Pride and Prejudice* (2005), which have attracted international tourists to the screened locations. Australia also expanded their recognition considerably worldwide as a tourist destination after quite a few successful films like *Mad Max* (1980), *The Man from Snowy River* (1982) and *Crocodile Dundee* (1986). The natural environment represented in the films is a factor which provoked many Americans, who have a special attachment to the wilderness, to travel to the destinations (Riley and Van Doren, 1992). Lately, films and television series set in many regions of South Korea have motivated a number of new international tourist flows, especially Japanese female tourists to South Korea (see Iwashita, 2006; Riley and van Doren, 1992).

Yorkshire was selected as the case study area, due to the high numbers of film induced tourists that visit its film sites as it has been the film location for a number of popular English television series. Yorkshire is located in the north east of England and is the largest county in Britain with a population of around five million. The three most well-known British television shows currently filmed in (and based around) Yorkshire are sitcom *Last of the Summer Wine* (1973–present), drama series *Heartbeat* and soap opera *Emmerdale* (1972–present), the latter two of which are produced by Yorkshire Television. *Last of the Summer Wine* in particular is noted for holding the record of longest-running comedy series in the world, from 1973 until the present. Several noted films have also been filmed in Yorkshire, including *The Full Monty* (1997), which won an Academy Award (Iwashita, 2006; Wikipedia, 2008).

A theoretical overview of the film induced tourism phenomenon

Introduction

One of the most important roles of brand image is its impact on the tourism decision-making process. Many researchers (Mayo, 1973; Mayo and Jarvis, 1981) have clearly stated that the perceptions of destinations and the purchase decisions are positively linked, indicating that the image of a destination is a key selection factor (Woodside and Lysons, 1989). Lawson and Baud-Bovy (1977) suggest that the destination image should be cost effective, new and sincere (Kim and Richardson, 2003). More often than not tourism destinations have been vaguely positioned from its sources of tourist demand and as a

result most tourists, primarily first time visitors, will have restricted knowledge of the destination. These tourists can neither check what they are purchasing nor can they try a sample of it. For this reason, many will rely on their perceptions of the destination and as such, choosing a holiday will generally be considered a high-risk decision. Hunt (1975) believes that what potential tourists assume about a destination may well shape perceptions or images, which take away from the successful development of a destination (McGuckin and Demick, 2000).

The relationship between destination image and film induced tourism

Media containing 3D-visual and acoustic effects, for example film, DVD and television can help create organic images of a destination by presenting a vivid experience which appears less biased or is less recognizable as promotional (Schofield, 1996). Such data clearly increases destination awareness, which can lead to a tangible visit to the destination depicted in the film (Riley et al., 1998; Riley and Van Doren, 1992; Stewart, 1997). For that reason, understanding the building of vivid mental images is very important in understanding the impact of images on tourists' attitudes and behaviours (MacInnis and Price, 1987; Schlosser et al., 2003).

Film associated promotion can be one of the most successful tools for enhancing tourist awareness as it presents product features and builds a visual image of a destination (Belch and Belch, 2001). Its advantages over other means of communication include its emotional appeal and visual images, which provide potential tourists with a pre-taste of a destination (Hanefors and Mossberg, 2002). Furthermore, distinctive visual components are crucial for effectively forming and communicating images (Smith and MacKay, 2001).

Films play a key role in influencing people's images and perceptions of a destination prior to their arrival at the destination. As Butler (1990) argues, films as visual media are more important to tourists than printed sources of information because they tend to be more reliable. This is supported by Schofield (1996), who maintains that media images do not have the same perceived bias of printed marketing material. It is well documented that film can positively enhance the awareness of destinations and affect the tourist decision making process (Macionis, 2004). Just as films and media can create positive destination images, there are cases, then again,

where films have formed an unfavourable imagery, which may result in off-putting destination images and perceptions. Certainly, for a destination to take advantage of its film and media exposure, it is crucial that an appropriate and positive image is depicted (Macionis, 2004).

The international film market is growing, with popular films reaching a vast audience in important tourism markets. Films that replicate the authenticity of a destination be it scenery, the culture, key landmarks or even universal themes, are attracting tourists to visit the scenes that they have seen on the big screen. Tourism stakeholders can endorse destinations, leveraging off carefully chosen films, which emulate the image of the destination in partnership with their own (Beeton, 2002).

Macionis (2004) discovered the international exposure a film can provide a destination; a film is an advertisement potentially viewed by millions of people who may be tempted to become film induced tourists. A film may undoubtedly create and prolong more interest in a destination in a way that Destination Marketing Organization (DMO)² cannot financially afford to do (Beeton, 2002). Tourists can also learn about destinations in a passive way without the aggressive impressions intrinsic in paid advertising (Beeton, 2002). As branding has become a fundamental element of tourism destinations, with image being one of the most significant elements of a brand, it is vital that the images presented by the popular media are reviewed and bear in mind how they transcend to tourism (Beeton, 2001). These images can be closely linked with film induced tourism which will be examined next.

Negative impacts of film induced tourism on image

Beeton (2001) testifies that there are three basic types of film induced images which can be deemed undesirable, the first being created by a negative storyline, such as criminal activities. There are times where pressure from the destination has succeeded in prohibiting filming access to a location due to such perceived negative storylines, but it is disputable as to whether the negative images actually deter or attract tourists. Second, a negative tourism image can result from the formation of idealistic tourist expectations and aspects of authenticity. For instance, tourists to some destinations have been let down when the community does not behave or dress in the way shown in a film or television series. A third

negative image can arise when a destination is too successful in attracting tourists, giving rise to negative community impacts such as loss of privacy and overcrowding. For example, Amish country in Lancaster County Pennsylvania, USA received a great deal of tourist interest following the popular film *Witness* (1985). This was not greeted enthusiastically by the community (Beeton, 2001).

Countless films have been filmed on location in New Orleans (USA). Consequently, viewers have developed a sense of the people, places and attractions of the city. There are several portrayals of corruption, violence and terrible weather in these films. New Orleans might also come across as a hazardous city that is not fitting for families. This is not essentially the case as portrayed in the film *Double Jeopardy* (1999). Bordelon and Dimanche's (2003) research supports Beeton (2001) in that the unenthusiastic imagery issues linked with film induced tourism can have a harmful effect on the development of a destination. Riley et al. (1998) also recognize a number of off-putting operational impacts due to the escalating tourist numbers at film related destinations in the USA (Riley et al., 1998).

Positive impacts of film induced tourism on image

Television series such as *Ballykissangel* (1996–2001) and *All Creatures Great and Small* (1978–1990) are still being televised worldwide even though they are no longer being filmed. The Empire State Building is a film emblem for New York films such as *Sleepless in Seattle* (1993). Many destinations worldwide, cited in films, have attained iconic status. A regular image of Rome – *La Dolce Vita* (1960), of romantic Paris, of swinging London, of hippie San Francisco and gritty but sophisticated New York are put forward. Ever since the 1950s, Las Vegas like New York and Los Angeles, has acquired an elite destination in film making and many films have been set entirely or to a certain extent in the city including *Viva Las Vegas* (1964), *The Godfather* (1972, 1974, 1990), *Honeymoon in Vegas* (1992), *Leaving Las Vegas* (1995) and *Casino* (1995) (Morgan and Pritchard, 1998).

Many researchers have made an attempt to summarize the process of image development as linked to tourism promotion and destination choice (see Echtner and Brent Ritchie, 1993). Without a doubt, destination image is more and more recognized as a fundamental element of the

travel process in terms of its effects on normal tourist behaviour and the decision making process in particular (Morgan and Pritchard, 1998). Croy and Walker (2003) evaluated the growth in tourism by way of considering the generic process of image building in tourism and its role in destination selection. A major focus of their research assesses the roles of organic images (film) versus induced images (advertising) in generating destination familiarity and motivation. In the case of *The Lord of the Rings*, the trilogy built on and improved New Zealand's tourism image. The improvement of the image, by way of organic and induced sources, was subsequently converted into travel behaviour with tourists saying that the films played a big part in their decision to visit (Macionis, 2004).

Methodology

Background

Yorkshire, in the UK, was selected as the case study area due to its many popular television series locations. Yorkshire has been the film destination for a number of well-liked English television series and as such is the focus of much destination research in the tourism discipline (Mordue, 2001). In this research, the case studies being employed are *Last of the Summer Wine*, *Heartbeat* and *All Creatures Great and Small*. They were chosen because of high levels of visitation due to their filming in the area (Beeton, 2002). As mentioned previously, a two phased approach was adopted for the purpose of this research. The first involved gathering and analyzing quantitative data (tourist survey) regarding the film induced tourist, while the second phase consisted of strategic conversations with the key tourism and film stakeholders behind the development of the Yorkshire brand (see Figure 1).

These approaches supplemented one another and each was successful in attaining the necessary information to satisfy the research objectives. The emergent 'image related' themes and assorted issues that arose from this secondary data (literature reviews), which form the basis for both the tourist survey and consequently the strategic conversations are outlined in Figure 2.

The tourist survey

The initial phase of the primary research was a survey conducted through face-to-face interviews with a sample of tourists to Yorkshire.



Figure 1. The Multi Method Approach

Brannick (1997) considers that a structured survey is a competent data collection instrument when the researcher knows exactly what data is required. It is typically administered to a large sample of respondents (over 50). The aspects of survey design, question content, question phrasing and survey response format necessitate special attention when putting together a structured interview (Carson et al., 2000). The two part questionnaire comprised 33 questions and classified the respondents by age, first visit to Yorkshire, gender, length of stay, origin, occupation, party size, travelling party, whether they travelled independently or as part of a package.

The Strategic Conversation

In the course of reviewing the academic literature on qualitative research techniques, it was shown that the mode of interview itself has moved away from a fairly structured format to a more un-conventional, semi-structured and unstructured procedure (Carson et al., 2000). The in-depth interview has now arrived at a stage where a more truthful and creative role is being played by the interviewer and this has been referred to as a 'strategic conversation' method (Ratcliffe, 2002). Ratcliffe (2002) states that the term strategic conversation has been referred to by van der Heijden (1996) as the continuing process of dialect that takes place within an organization as part of a scenario planning exercise to form a shared mental model of the organization, its goals and the way in which it sets out to achieve them. Carson et al. (2001) argue that

with ability and good fortune a researcher may be able to get the interviewee involved in a conversation sooner than an interview, and the conversation will incorporate the general topic and associated questions without the interviewee knowing they were actually premeditated. Subsequently, in a good interview, the questions are often revealed before they have to be directly asked (Carson et al., 2001).

Miles et al. (2006) state that strategic conversations are multi-directional multi-dimensional communication devices for determining and incorporating the strategic intent of management with both the firm's capabilities and the competitive realities they encounter. For strategic conversations to be successful in strategy making, communications must clearly include both talking and contemplative listening by all participants. Characteristically, they have been used to produce open channels of unfiltered information between managers and ground level employees (see Kochan et al., 2003). They also help the employees to appreciate the strategic intent of management while at the same time facilitating managers to acquire a richer and more truthful understanding of both the possible future the company faces and the ability of the company to align itself with its desired future (Miles et al., 2006). Despite the fact that strategic conversations have been used to bring into line the perceptions, values and concerns of management (see Chesley and Wenger, 1999; Liedtka and Rosenblum, 1996), insignificant work has been done on leveraging strategic conversations to better support the aspirations of management and other stakeholders (see Bronn and Bronn, 2003). Buysse and Verbeke (2003) ascertain that more proactive environmental strategies are linked with a deeper and broader treatment of the stakeholders. In actual fact, without employing stakeholders in strategic conversations, management runs the risk of isolating the stakeholders and its own employees, forming an attitude that advocates a limited perspective of the company, its abilities, and potential futures (Miles et al., 2006).

Ratcliffe (2002) highlighted many advantages of the strategic conversation. For example, to,

- Understand the models of the decision makers;
- Convey the trend breaking developments;
- Be familiar with new external signals of potential change;
- Extract strategic insights and perceptions;



Figure 2. Overall emergent themes and associated issues

- Determine the future concerns of key stakeholders;
- Corroborate issues and trends;
- Help in understanding predictability, impact and improbability;
- Detect a variety of perspectives;
- Attempt to reduce any difficulties;
- Establish definite competencies;
- Entrust decision makers to the planning process;
- Identify problematic respondents that might obstruct the process;
- Decide on the strategic agenda.

Up to now, the strategic conversation is very much a practitioner-driven approach. Concerning further research on strategic conversations, there is a clear gap to be closed. A foundation for an evaluation could be to differentiate between content and process and to develop on that basis

a method for evaluation. Second, strategic conversation often could be used as a tool for large global business. Finally, they can be enhanced if they are amalgamated with other potential methods such as creativity techniques; a precise mix of methods could also be assessed (Miles et al., 2006).

In contrast to these cited strengths, Meitzner and Reger (2005) maintain that strategic conversations have many weaknesses including:

- This interviewing technique can be very time-consuming;
- A more qualitative approach needs to put a firm weight on the selection of appropriate interviewees and in reality this is not an easy task to accomplish;
- A profound knowledge and familiarity of the field under examination is crucial.

Information and data from different sources have to be collected and interpreted which prolongs the strategic conversation even more;

- It may be hard not to concentrate on black and white scenarios or the most likely scenario during the interviewing process.

Using the strategic conversation in Yorkshire

Since the research on destination imagery for regional tourism locations has been in short supply, an exploratory research design was implemented to exemplify the changes and opportunities in designing a consistent branding strategy for up-and-coming regional destinations. The issue of monitoring of the brand was explored, as it is unclear if this has been carried out in Yorkshire to date. Also more detailed qualitative research explored the extent to which tourism related branding and imagery reflected the wider image, which the county wishes to portray in its Area Tourism Partnerships (ATP).³ These strategic conversations enabled the researcher to explore the emergent issues. It was also helpful that the researcher is not from or living in Yorkshire, therefore any possible interviewer bias was minimized. Ratcliffe (2002) determined that there is in fact no set process for the performing of strategic conversations or rules regarding participants. However, a few comments can be made in the light of some recent studies (van der Heijden, 1996), which the researcher put into practice in conducting the strategic conversations in Yorkshire:

- It is imperative that several strategic conversations are held, as these will determine the strategic vision. For the purpose of this research study, data was collected via 27 strategic conversations with the key stakeholders behind the development of the Yorkshire brand;
- The nature of the strategic conversation obviously changes as the number of interviews carried out increases. Through the tourist survey and the literature review, several themes and issues emerged that needed to be explored further and these were adapted for each individual strategic conversation undertaken;
- Certain potential respondents cannot to be ignored when choosing interviewees, either by way of their power or because of the information they can make available. All respondents chosen for this study had extensive and specialist knowledge of the specific matters pertaining to the Yorkshire brand and as it was felt that they were the most effective source for obtaining detailed in-depth information;
- It is vital that the researcher is professed as credible, so as to gain the trust of the interviewee. An in-depth knowledge of the subject matter being investigated is vital, as this will allow the researcher to gain respect and also challenge or even explore what the interviewee presents. Telephone calls were made to each interviewee to confirm details and an email was also sent to them with a list of themes to be reviewed during the strategic conversations. The purpose of this was to highlight the aims of the forthcoming strategic conversation, the background to the research study being undertaken and the future plan for the dissemination of the results. This allowed the participants to prepare themselves for the discussion. The themes and issues identified for discussion, emerged from a combination of the secondary data reviewed and the tourist survey undertaken;
- Perhaps, the most critical feature of the strategic conversation compared with other forms of in-depth interview is the personality and function of the researcher. There has to be reciprocated reverence and understanding between the interviewee and the researcher and also an ability for each to communicate with equal appreciation of the other's knowledge and experience (Ratcliffe, 2002). Ratcliffe (2002) proposes a few broad guidelines, which the researcher considered when trying to undertake successful strategic conversations:
- The strategic conversation must start by outlining the motive behind the research, the method being used and the way in which the collected data will be disseminated. The issues identified included the extent of the respondent's consultation with tourists and film stakeholders, the strength of the Yorkshire brand, future marketing strategies, the impact of film induced tourism on the county and its linkages with destination branding;
- They should be performed with a wide line of inquiry, intended to endorse a free flow of conversation. The conversations in this research followed this structure, a loose but semi-structured approach based on questions of a general nature derived from a review of the

literature and the tourist survey. The issue of brand monitoring was explored, as it is unclear if this has been carried out in Yorkshire to date. Also more detailed qualitative research explored the extent to which tourism related branding and imagery reflected the wider image which the county wishes to portray in its ATPs;

- Strategic conversations are best conducted in an environment familiar to the interviewee. They should also be carried out at a time suitable for the interviewee. The strategic conversations were carried out at a suitable time and venue instigated by the interviewee;
- The suggested time for a strategic conversation is typically set at an hour but in reality, most surpass this. The researcher made the interviewee aware of the time commitment required and scheduled a time suitable for both the interviewer and the interviewee. The conversations took between 1–2 hours to complete. Telephone interviews were arranged with those individuals where a face-to-face meeting was not possible;
- It is essential to stress the classified nature of the interview. This was highlighted prior to the commencement of the interview;
- The examination of the conversations can be a very lengthy process. It is normal to set aside quite a few hours to evaluate each interview. Interviewee responses were documented in written and oral form, which were electronically resent to the interviewee for further editing and clarification. This was a lengthy process, taking a number of hours to complete each individual interview;
- The best way of starting a strategic conversation is to present a brief set of questions such as: how did you arrive in your present position? An appropriate way of closing a strategic conversation may comprise a question like: what might you have done differently? (Ratcliffe, 2002). As the conversations were conducted with a number of experts behind the Yorkshire brand, comparison of responses revealed a variety of different interpretations of the issues and so it was concluded that the interview format did not lead to any biases.

Ratcliffe (2002) proposes that the unusual nature of strategic conversations does not mean that the scrutiny is any less thorough than the conventional interview findings. In contrast, the results from strategic conversations necessitate

a regimented approach towards both process and substance (Ratcliffe, 2002). Additionally, strategic conversations can look into the how's and whys plus the what's of experience (Ratcliffe, 2002). In this study, the strategic conversations enabled the researcher to explore the emergent themes and issues mentioned previously.

Findings

The brand image can be a strong tourism destination motivator

The stakeholders (27) concur in that visual images or symbols play an important role in promoting a destinations image. The positive portrayal of destination icons can also reaffirm the status of destination. They create the experience and set the tourist agenda as to who would go to Paris and not go to the Eiffel tower or who would go to London and visit a red phone box. The perception that people have of the UK is of a wealth of historic buildings and quaint villages. This is changing from the old traditional image to a more modern one such as the cosmopolitan Sheffield. The power of visual images or symbols can play a significant role in promoting a destination both nationally and internationally. It was put forward by VisitBritain⁴, that when those images appear in a moving image such as a powerful film, or even a well shot commercial, the image can be associated with other attractions within the destination and can as a result create the desire to visit.

Many tourists are looking for something different, so what the brand says about a destination can either encourage or discourage tourists. The destination brand image shows that a place will determine its appeal to whichever group of travellers it is aiming to attract. Once the destination is decided upon, the secondary factors, like cost, are considered, as people decide where to stay and what sort of experience they want in the destination. This was defended by many stakeholders (20) as the media is increasing its influence through the internet while the YTB's recent *Make Yorkshire Yours* campaign has tried to change the image of the county.

The National Trust⁵ maintains that the media portrays Blackpool as a family fun destination. Ireland seems to want the public to think that the place is full of country bars with beautiful red heads serving ice cold Guinness, that Scotland is full of mountains, and Australia is the big adventure. VisitBritain have started tourism related theme days, such as the royal and stately

homes days which have been well received by tourists. Also, the British heritage, scenery, cream teas and quaint villages build on this image. The Yorkshire Tourist Board (YTB)⁶ has done this in their regional marketing strategy: *Bold, Bright, Future!* They plan to increase tourist numbers by 5% per annum until 2010. This target was set by Yorkshire Forward in their *Strategic Framework for the Visitor Economy* strategic document. In Yorkshire, brand image is not perhaps the most important factor for success as it should be noted that 85% of their tourists are repeat visitors. The tourist image of York itself changes once tourists arrive, as they are surprised by how vibrant and modern it actually is.

The images portrayed in films/television play an important role in influencing travellers' expectations of Yorkshire

The National Trust has allowed several documentary programmes to be filmed on their properties for free as they recognize this sort of exposure is worth many millions in advertising value. Due to this collaboration, their tourist numbers have increased when they linked the many popular television series and films images with the tourist advert. There are so many more ways now of seeing an image: film, internet, mobile phones, posters, print and television. Screens and text have a very symbolic relationship. People are reading more and if the books tie in with a film, they are even more successful, such as the *Master and Commander* (2003), Dickens and *Bleak House* (2005) novels. Conversely it should be noted that one of the strongest international products for Yorkshire is the Brontë connection and has been for centuries. Young people are reading less and watching more television than the older generation but research is needed to support this. The popular Scottish television series *The Monarch of the Glen* (2000–2005) was only meant to be a pilot. The series tried to link with original books but was unsuccessful, maybe due to the fact that it was filmed in a private house.

Screen Yorkshire⁷ mentioned that if the tourist advert has the right image it can dramatically increase people's desire to visit. The *Picture of Britain* (2005) and *Coast* (2003-pres.) travel series, the popular television series, *The Royal* (2003-pres.) and *Heartbeat* (1992-pres.) are examples of this but it's very hard to quantify as Scarborough District Council⁸ have witnessed.

A positive portrayal of destinations through television series can certainly influence the image and hold up well for repeat viewing. Many different types of series can showcase destinations. It is believed that young people are using the Internet as an interactive source more than ever. In China, there are only twenty international films shown annually, which is changing due to piracy laws, which has become a big issue. It is imperative that the UK Film Council⁹ gets some British based films shown there as they have the power to change the image of a region.

The series based in the Yorkshire Dales are portrayed very positively and they would like to continually use them as sometimes this image can also be negative as seen with the film *Little Voice* (1998) and Scarborough. The positive images portrayed in the media can attract attention to the city and the surrounding areas, besides the beautiful scenery. It is important to promote the home produced food (Yorkshire Lamb and Wensleydale Cheese) and the farmers markets. Most definitely Yorkshire is about the outdoors; conversely images should be more vibrant that is currently portrayed in terms of culture, heritage and quality.

Yorkshire is trying to re-image itself especially the cities such as Leeds and Sheffield with their 'Café Culture'. There is also Yorkshires history and culture. The York Tourist Bureau is currently working to promote York as a lively, vibrant, historic city. The county's tourist product should also change in collaboration with the brand. It was argued that as a county, Yorkshire has a very diverse offering and although the brand values associated with this rural image is very strong and attractive; the YTB would ideally like this to be portrayed in a manner, which is aspirational and portrays the region as high quality and contemporary.

With the positive portrayal of locations in a dramatic and inspirational way and the association of popular actors, the right film can have the effect in shaping images of a destination to a captive audience. The images portrayed in films certainly play an important role in both shaping images and influencing traveller's expectations of Yorkshire due to the power of the media. The northern city of Newcastle has successfully managed to improve its image in the last few years due its positive portrayal in the media (90% of all images are visual). The images portrayed in films and television create awareness and positive attractive images are very beneficial.

Screen Yorkshire proposes that if an iconic image such as Big Ben appears in a film then it

tends to strengthen the London brand and also tourists have more access to sources of media information. It was recommended by VisitBritain that the media is very strong and most people in the developed world are exposed to increasing amounts of visual images from the big screen to their mobile phones. Websites also play a big part, but they have to be easy to navigate, and if a Yorkshire related article appears in a national newspaper, it can have a big knock on effect to the county.

Film re-imaging rural areas

Many stakeholders (23) state that the influence of filming re-imaging rural areas is not that important, as tourists are wise enough to know that reality is never like the fiction. It hardly works in reverse as most of the images of New York come mainly from crime shows but tourism is hardly affected. On the other hand it has already proven to be effective, certainly in the case of *The Lord of the Rings*; the trilogy provided New Zealand with an annual destination marketing opportunity at each screening, which maximized tourist attractiveness to the country. Nonetheless, not everyone who visited New Zealand would have watched the film, but they might have seen the trailer. Subsequently, each time the production is screened on the small screen; it could well provide another stimulus. Television is just one of a number of media that allow people to get an impression of what the city of York is like. This is mainly done through regional news coverage rather than advertising.

Busby and Klug (2001) discovered in their research about the film *Notting Hill* (1999), that two-thirds of the respondents concurred with the fact that films and television series can promote tourism to a specified destinations (Hanefors and Mossberg, 2002). The key findings of this study also support Gartner's (1996) argument that image formation agents like news and popular culture can alter destination images in a relatively short time period. The promoting of tourism destinations is turning out to be progressively more aggressive as destinations will need to find creative solutions and maximize their visual identity. In the YTB's strategy one of their aims is to increase their domestic brand awareness even though the awareness of the Yorkshire brand is very strong. Conversely, it is about making something different or providing an experience that cannot be gained elsewhere. For Kirklees Metropolitan Council¹⁰, the brands that they are currently using are the *Last of the*

Summer Wine and the Pennine Yorkshire brands, whilst at a county level it is about dispelling visions of Yorkshire and enabling consumers to *Make Yorkshire Yours* special to them.

Tourist stakeholders should be aware of the benefits of using positive destination images in a film or a television series

Tourist agencies should also be aware of the possible gain for having positive images of a destination in a film (Bordelon and Dimanche, 2003). Then again, the promotional wherewithal of film is not the same and some films and television series have little impact while others may be both powerful and unforgettable such as the attractive scenery, which help in creating a film encounter of durable importance. The promotional capability of film is not equal and some television series and films have little impact, while others may be both influential and memorable for instance the setting, which can help in creating a film experience of lasting importance. This is supported by some of the stakeholders (5) interviewed. The film agencies and the television companies should be encouraged to engage with the tourist stakeholders more. This has recently happened between the Peak District National Park¹¹ Authority and Universal Studios with *Pride and Prejudice*.

The spin off from film induced tourism can be wonderful but the tourist stakeholders need to know what is being filmed in their area and to take an interest in it. Kirklees Metropolitan Council propose that the tourist stakeholders need to be aware of the potential gain for featuring positive images of a destination in a film, which should also be part of the areas tourist strategy. To support this idea, the film induced tourism concept could be developed as part of the destination's overall tourism product on the basis of the destination being a popular location for film and/or television filming and also more so in destinations that are looking for an alternative form of due to the decline in local industries since the recession of the 1980s.

Final thoughts on film and re-imaging in a tourism destination

The development of the image management strategy

Films have been, without a doubt a tourist inducing ingredient, turning destinations of little or

no importance into much visited tourist attractions. Even if not all films have such an effect, nonetheless it cannot be disputed that films in general do affect the image of destination. For that reason, it is important that a well-planned image management plan to be produced for destinations. This is fundamental in ensuring the sustainable and successful development of the destination. In the advancement of the image management strategy, a long-term view is also necessary. The outcomes of research in New Zealand, illustrate a short term focus which smoothes the progress of film production as it needs to concentrate on the related economic impacts, though an understanding of film as a positive image enhancer is also necessary. Planning needs to consider a long term deliberation of image and the impact of film on such an image (Croy and Walker, 2003).

The conventional tourism marketing mediums such as television promotion and literacy have become dull and even though these mediums tend to be quite widespread, their success is minimal compared to that of films. A tourist visiting a destination after seeing the location in a film or television series is an emerging phenomenon and due to the momentous impacts, many films have had their locations research into the issues relating to film induced tourism (Safari Kinead, 2002). Film induced tourism is partially based on tourist demands to escape reality to a better world represented in films. By understanding the film tourist phenomenon, tourism and film stakeholders can better meet experiences, thus expanding on the positive impacts of such destinations (Carl et al., 2007).

The film induced tourism phenomenon

This research study has put forward a stimulating insight into the film induced tourism phenomenon. It has substantiated some earlier research on this phenomenon and is supplementary confirmation of the powerful effect that films and television series can have on a destination. It has publicized that such tourism is a versatile and exciting concept and triumph is dependent on many features beyond the control or remit of the destination. Undoubtedly, research is necessary to investigate these and other factors relating to film induced tourism. There is also a call for more research into the expressive and behavioural aspects of such tourism. Countless variables may affect a film and television series influence on viewers' attitude with regard to a

destination, therefore on tourism, so responses to these variables warrant additional investigation (Hudson and Ritchie, 2006). It has been revealed that film induced tourism has the capability of presenting many opportunities but also generates many drawbacks mentioned earlier. The perception of Yorkshire as a film induced tourism destination is not widely welcomed by the stakeholders (10) and the implications are that sustaining an apparent balance between Yorkshire's present tourism product and maximizing opportunities in fresh markets is the most appropriate way forward.

Brand image can be a strong tourism destination motivator

This study found that a strong motivator in creating interest is in fact the destination brand image which concurs with studies undertaken by Awaritefe (2004), Bordelon and Dimanche (2002), Lam and Ap (2006), Pearce (1982) and Ross (1993). Yorkshire has a strong positive brand image through its television series, films, books and a general feeling of nostalgia for the county in the way that it is portrayed by the YTB. Many tourists are looking for something different, so what the brand says about a destination can either encourage or discourage tourists. The destination brand image shows that a place will appeal to whichever group of travellers it is aiming to attract.¹²

Summary

Yorkshire was selected as the case study area as it has been the film location for a number of popular English television series and a high numbers of film induced tourists visit its film sites. It cannot be assumed that the results from this research could be automatically used to benchmark other such destinations on how to brand themselves based on film induced tourism, as each destination has difficult variables to manage such as political and government enforced strategies and plans. Although, there are reasons to be cautious about generalizing in relation to these findings, there is little doubt that many of the themes and issues could be applicable to other such tourism destinations, with some minor adjustments.

The use of film images and storylines in destination marketing is one of the most recognizable uses of film induced tourism. Emotionally based images from films and television series can provide some competitive advantages for a

destination and help them to compete in what can be a crowded marketplace (Beeton, 2002). This is supported by O'Connor et al. (2008). If Beeton's (2002) research findings are accepted, then the question remains of how long this image will be important for tourists visiting such destinations.

Notes

1. Film induced tourism is the collective term used for the study of tourist visits to a destination or attraction as a result of the destination being featured on the cinema screen, DVD, television or on video - (Hudson and Ritchie, 2006; 256).
2. A DMO is an organization at any level which is responsible for the marketing of an identifiable destination. Therefore, this excludes separate government departments that are responsible for planning and policy (Pike 2004: 14).
3. The ATP is a regional tourism partnership, which is in place in each of Yorkshire's tourism regions and it comprises of representatives from the public and private sectors, as well from Yorkshire Forward, Yorkshire Culture and the YTB.
4. VisitBritain, the national tourism agency, promotes the UK internationally in 36 markets and England in the UK, France, Germany, Ireland and the Netherlands (VisitBritain, 2008).
5. National Trust is responsible for conserving and enhancing natural beauty, wildlife, culture and heritage in the UK. The National Trust also promotes opportunities for understanding and enjoyment of the special qualities of the National Parks by the public (The National Trust 2007).
6. The YTB is the official tourism agency responsible for representing and helping to generate sustainable tourism for the Yorkshire tourism economy, while representing the whole of the Yorkshire and northern Lincolnshire's tourism industry (YTB 2008).
7. Screen Yorkshire is the regional screen agency for filming, broadcasting and digital media industries in the Yorkshire, and Humber region and is part of the regional screen agency network which covers the whole of the UK (Screen Yorkshire, 2008).
8. The Moors and Coast ATP is responsible for the promotion and development of tourism in Scarborough area.
9. The UK Film Council is the Government backed strategic agency for film in the UK (UK Film Council 2008).
10. The West Yorkshire ATP is responsible for the promotion and development of tourism in the Kirklees area.
11. The North York Moors National Park (NYMNP)/ National Parks are run by the NPA, who have twin purposes of preserving and enhancing the UK's

natural beauty while promoting their enjoyment to the public (National Park 2008).

12. Edgington, Mr Harvey; Broadcast and Media Liaison Officer, The National Trust (9th August 2006).

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